candidates (which he kept shuffling until the last, based on internal surveys and opinion poll results). He did address four massive 'Siddham (Ready)' rallies beforehand, though, in each region of the state. Starting with Bheemili in Visakhapatnam on January 27, the venues were designed differently, with elevated ramps leading to the centre where Jagan stood and spoke. As he walked the ramp, frenzied followers went into overdrive taking selfies with the CM. Having created the initial momentum, Jagan is now following it up with 'Memantha Siddham (We are all ready)', a 21-day bus tour of all the districts, with multiple meetings, whistle-stops and a rally at the end of each day. The YSRCP campaign narrative presents Jagan as the lone hero, "Arjuna not Abhimanyu" (in his own words), fighting it out against the 'Opposition villains', who have "ganged up against him and the people".

On the other side of the road, TDP chief N. Chandrababu Naidu is on a similar statewide 'Praja Galam (Voice of the people)' bus yatra, which, incidentally, was also flagged off on the same day—March 27. Since his 52-day incarceration in September-October 2023 in the skill development scam case, the 73-year-old Naidu has been all fire and brimstone, calling out Jagan's "misrule" and listing the financial scandals he's embroiled in in the courts (the YSRCP leader, too, had spent 16 months in jail in 2013-14, but had come out the stronger for it).

Naidu is hoping the combined force of his alliance will be enough to edge out the YSRCP, like it did in 2014. Analysts point out that both sides are formidable, commanding vote shares of 45 per cent and above in elections since 2014. The NDA challenge is to ensure that the worm keeps inching up this time around.



ANI

WITH THE PEOPLE TDP chief Naidu campaigns in Chittoor, Mar. 26

SINCE HIS JAIL SOJOURN IN SEPT. '23, TDP CHIEF NAIDU HAS BEEN ALL FIRE AND BRIMSTONE, CALLING OUT JAGAN'S "MISRULE" AND LISTING THE ALLEGED FINANCIAL SCANDALS HE'S EMBROILED IN

The TDP has kept the lion's share (17) of the 25 Lok Sabha seats in the state, conceding just six to the BJP and two to the JSP. In the 175-seat assembly, it is contesting in an overwhelming 144, with the JSP allotted 21 and the BJP 10. The TDP is also fielding several 'resourceful' candidates, including turncoats from the YSRCP and Congress, and will be hoping for a sustained campaign from them.

Jagan and Naidu represent two of the dominant castes in the state, and also hail from the same Rayalaseema region. The Reddys and Kammas make up just eight and five per cent of the population, respectively, but have much higher representation in the assembly compared to the numerically larger Other Backward Classes (OBCs). The Kapus, a forward caste of farmers, who also have strength in numbers, and the OBC cohorts have been pushing for reservations and a larger share of seats for some time now.

Jagan is calling the elections "a class war" and is betting on the slew of welfare schemes that he has launched for the disadvantaged to take him past the finish line. The 38 schemes have reached some 125 million beneficiaries (many of them for multiple schemes), and involved an investment of over Rs 4.2 lakh crore over four years (till January 2024). What differentiated it from other states was the elaborate Gram Sachivalayam and Ward Sachivalayam (GSWS) network that was set up for this. The GSWS volunteers did yeoman work during the Covid-19 containment phase and after in the doorstep delivery of welfare scheme benefits. The 'welfare calendar' with fixed timelines for delivery of services and transparent